

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Mr Ian Cooper

Address: 63 Holland Avenue Cheam Sutton SM2 6HT

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer objects to the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: I cannot support any initiative that will inevitably add to the congestion and parking issues already faced by residents in the area due to Avenue School drop off and pick up.

The roads around the proposed place of worship are congested and heavily parked at school drop off and collection times, leading to frustration for residents when wanting to leave or return home. It is impossible to park on Holland Avenue within 200-250m of home if arriving during this time. Furthermore, residents often suffer inconsiderate parking with driveways sometimes partially or fully blocked.

The effect is worst during afternoon pick up where frequent bottlenecks occur caused by congestion and excessive parking. I have observed numerous incidents of road rage and harassment on Holland Avenue. This will only get worse with an increase in vehicles circulating in the area looking for somewhere to park.

Supporters, some from far away are suggesting parking will not be an issue, but without any real justification of why they feel this way. On the contrary, objections from residents on Queens Road state that they suffer with haphazard parking by some of those attending Friday prayer at St Johns Church. I have experienced significant delay and frustration caused by inconsiderate parking on Northdown Road which had created an entirely avoidable bottleneck. Unfortunately, I have no reason to believe this behaviour will change when switching to the new venue, and this will regrettably divide rather than unite the community.

Well-meaning but ultimately flawed Transport Statement and Travel Plan documents have been

submitted. The Transport Statement mentions three Traffic Marshals, among their responsibilities are to "ensure that visitors' cars do not block the driveways of nearby residents" and "ensure that visitors to the place of worship do not park off-street in the driveways of nearby residents". This is alarming and implies the applicant is well aware of the potential parking problems the proposed use of this site will raise.

The Travel Plan mentions that around 250 people will attend the site for Friday prayers, resulting in at least 80 cars associated with the site and leading to a 76% parking occupancy on all roads within a 400m radius according to a survey. I note that the parking occupancy survey was undertaken at 13:00 on a Friday, before many parents had turned up to collect their children, yet prayers will take place until 13:35 or 13:40 depending on time of year. This overlaps with parents parking in advance of school pick up, when Holland Avenue is usually 100% parked to at least 200m from my address. Hence the 76% occupancy rate is likely to be far higher in practice, and certainly higher than the Council's own definition of parking stress of 85%. A visit to the area during term time at school pick up is strongly recommended so that decision makers may experience for themselves the current situation.

I would like to ask the planning committee to listen carefully to the views of the residents who live nearest to the site and who will be most affected by the proposal, the majority of whom do not support it for the reasons given in their objections. I feel that this application should be refused until proper thought has been applied to how congestion and parking issues will be managed, and practical solutions rather than targets and initiatives are put forward to address them.